From here on, their new home consisted of three rooms on the ground floor of a doctor's villa, decorated with grubby camel-coloured 1940s' wallpaper and outmoded furniture. There was an adjoining kitchenette. Erich slept in a tiny adjacent bedroom, Margot on a camp bed in the hall. 'It was so dark that fluorescent tube lights burned day and night,' Honecker's lawyer Friedrich Wolff recalled. 'In the middle of the living room was an oval table with five chairs, a glass cabinet was crammed with Russian books, and in the corner, two huge armchairs faced the TV set.'19 Food was delivered thrice daily from the hospital kitchen (usually boiled pork, mint tea and enormous quantities of white bread). Living temporarily apart from reality, the couple padded around in slippers, took midday naps and devoured every book and newspaper they could find. They avoided outside contacts and distrusted the media but remained in regular touch with just a handful of friends and four lawyers.

'On average, we get up between seven and seven-thirty, breakfast is around nine,' Erich said at the time. 'Then we go tramping in the forest. Then the medical treatment and the daily examination by the doctor take place. After lunch, we go for another thirty- to forty-minute walk and after supper too.'20 Communication with doctors was in Russian and primarily through Margot, who had a decent grasp of the language. If necessary, an interpreter was called in. In the evenings, the couple consumed vast amounts of television from where they learned of the death of two old comrades: former building minister Wolfgang Junker, who hanged himself on 9 April, and Horst Sindermann who died a few days later.

Honecker's first interview since his downfall was given to Heinz Junge, an old communist comrade from the anti-Nazi resistance, who lived in the West, but became one of the few regular visitors to Beelitz. It revealed a sad and bitter man, angry at Moscow for what he felt was a betrayal, irritated at the West German government which was then in charge of his fate, and totally unrepentant about his past. He lamented:

Everything I did, I did in the knowledge I was doing something for the people and for peace. In the present situation they need